
DIPLOMATIC EMERGENCY INSTRUMENT

The Strait Freeze Protocol

*A Minimum Viable Ceasefire Consolidation Framework
with Northern Front Extension (Israel – Lebanon)*

Track A: The United States of America & the Islamic Republic of Iran

Track B: The State of Israel & the Lebanese Republic

(with linkage provisions binding both tracks)

Reference: SFP-2026-v1.2

Date of Issue: 26 May 2026

Status: For Immediate Consideration

Facilitators: Sultanate of Oman, State of Qatar, United States (Track B)

This instrument is deliberately short. It resolves only one thing: whether all four parties will stop shooting long enough to talk. It does not resolve the nuclear file, the sanctions architecture, the future of the Strait, the disarmament of Hezbollah, or Israeli troop positions in southern Lebanon. Those questions are explicitly deferred.

Preamble: The Crisis as of 26 May 2026

The Southern Front – Strait of Hormuz

In the early hours of 26 May 2026, United States Central Command conducted self-described 'self-defence strikes' against missile launch sites and mine-laying vessels near Bandar Abbas, southern Iran — some 70 kilometres from the Strait of Hormuz. Iranian media confirmed explosions in the area. Several IRGC personnel were killed. Iran's army spokesperson warned that any further attack would generate a 'far more severe' response. These events occurred while an Iranian delegation, led by parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, was travelling to Doha for negotiations.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio, speaking from New Delhi, stated the U.S. intended to keep the Strait open 'one way or another,' while President Trump claimed an agreement was 'largely negotiated.' Iran's Foreign Ministry countered that a deal was 'not imminent' and that no commitment had been made on nuclear issues.

The Northern Front – Israel, Hezbollah, and Lebanon

On the same day — 26 May 2026 — Israeli forces and Hezbollah clashed along a strategic river in southern Lebanon as Israeli troops attempted to push farther north, just three days before Lebanese and Israeli military delegations were due to meet for direct talks in Washington. One Israeli strike on the village of Mashghara killed twelve people, including several members of one family. Israel has intensified strikes in Tyre, Nabatieh, the Beqaa Valley, and other areas. Prime Minister Netanyahu has instructed the IDF to 'press the pedal even harder.' Hezbollah drone attacks on northern Israel have continued; eleven Israeli soldiers have been killed since the 8 April ceasefire.

The Iran-mediated demand has become explicit: Tehran wants the end of the U.S.-Iran war to include an end to Israeli operations in Lebanon. The Lebanese government, which came to power on a platform of state monopoly on arms, is pursuing direct talks with Israel while Hezbollah explicitly rejects those talks. The April 16 Israel-Lebanon ceasefire is, in the words of recent reporting, 'more nominal by the day.'

PURPOSE OF THIS INSTRUMENT: This protocol does not attempt to resolve any permanent status issue. It is a single-purpose emergency instrument designed to stop the operational bleeding on two fronts simultaneously — the Strait of Hormuz (Track A) and the Israel-Lebanon border (Track B) — and to create 72 hours of genuine silence in which broader negotiations can advance. Nothing in this document prejudices any party's position on the nuclear file, sanctions, the PGSA, Hezbollah's disarmament, Israeli withdrawal, or war reparations.

Architecture: Two Tracks, One Floor

This Protocol operates on two parallel tracks, linked at three carefully chosen points. Each track has its own parties, its own facilitator, and its own obligations. Neither track requires the other to function. But because both fronts are now feeding each other's escalation, this Protocol allows them to de-escalate in synchrony.

	Track A – Southern Front	Track B – Northern Front
Parties	United States & Iran	Israel & Lebanese Republic
Theatre	Strait of Hormuz, Persian Gulf, Iranian territorial waters	Israel-Lebanon border, southern Lebanon, northern Israel
Facilitator	Oman (lead), Qatar (host of current delegation)	United States (existing mediator since April 16 truce)
Spoiler	IRGC hardliners, U.S. hawks pushing maximalist demands	Hezbollah (rejects state-to-state talks), Israeli ultra-right cabinet members
What success looks like	72 hours of no strikes; Hormuz open to commercial traffic; blockade suspended	72 hours of no IDF strikes in Lebanon; no Hezbollah fire into Israel; delegation talks proceed

Part I: Track A – The Southern Front (U.S. – Iran)

Article 1: Immediate Cessation of Offensive Action

Upon entry into force of this Protocol, both Parties to Track A commit to an immediate, unconditional pause on all offensive military operations directed at the other Party's forces, vessels, aircraft, and fixed infrastructure. This pause takes effect at the moment of joint notification to the Omani and Qatari facilitators and requires no further documentation, ratification, or counter-signature to be binding.

The pause covers:

- All CENTCOM strikes on Iranian soil, territorial waters, and Iranian-flagged vessels.
- All IRGC naval operations involving interdiction, harassment, or mine-laying in or near the Strait of Hormuz.
- All drone and missile deployments by either Party directed at the other's forces.
- All cyber operations targeting the other Party's military command infrastructure.

The pause does not cover legitimate self-defence responses to incoming kinetic attack (defined as actual weapons fire or imminent physical threat to personnel — not surveillance, signalling, or posturing). Any self-defence action must be immediately reported to both facilitators within two hours of occurrence.

Article 2: The 72-Hour Window

The initial freeze period is 72 hours, automatically renewable. At Hour 70, both facilitators (Oman and Qatar) confirm to each Party whether the other has maintained compliance. If both confirm compliance, the freeze auto-renews for a further 72 hours without any additional action required. Renewal continues indefinitely until either Party delivers a written non-renewal notice to both facilitators with six hours advance notice — sufficient time to allow negotiators to reach safety.

This auto-renewal mechanism is the central structural feature of this Protocol. It removes the need for either side to make an active political decision to continue the freeze. Silence equals continuation. Only a deliberate, written act ends it.

Article 3: The Hormuz Minimum

Within 48 hours of this Protocol entering into force, Iran commits to permitting unrestricted passage of all commercial vessels through the Strait of Hormuz, subject only to standard UNCLOS navigation rules. No PGSA transit permits, tolls, or inspection requirements apply during the freeze period. The legal and sovereign status of PGSA authority is explicitly deferred — this is a temporary operational suspension, not a legal concession by Iran on its regulatory rights.

Simultaneously, the United States commits to suspending enforcement of its naval blockade on Iranian commercial ports for the duration of the freeze. U.S. Navy vessels will not board, inspect, or interdict Iranian-flagged commercial vessels. Carrier strike groups will maintain current positions and not advance toward Iranian territorial waters.

Article 4: Humanitarian Corridor – Non-Negotiable

Regardless of any other provision, and regardless of any breach, dispute, or suspension, a zero-cost, zero-delay humanitarian corridor through the Strait of Hormuz is established effective immediately upon entry into force. This corridor applies to all vessels carrying verified humanitarian cargo — food, medicine, fuel for civilian heating and cooking, and humanitarian relief supplies certified by WHO or ICRC. Oman's Royal Navy serves as the sole verification and escort authority. The corridor is legally non-divertible.

Article 5: Protection of Negotiating Delegations

Both Track A Parties affirm that the delegations currently present in Doha, Qatar — including the Iranian delegation led by parliament speaker Qalibaf and any U.S. counterparts — are protected persons under this Protocol. Qatar is designated as a protected neutral venue for the duration of negotiations.

Part II: Track B – The Northern Front (Israel – Lebanon)

Track B addresses the Israel-Hezbollah conflict through the Lebanese state as formal counterparty. This design is deliberate. Hezbollah is not a signatory and will not be. The Lebanese government, which has publicly committed to disarming Hezbollah, is the only Lebanese authority with legal capacity to enter international agreements. Iran's leverage over Hezbollah is treated as Iran's contribution to Track B — delivered through Track A, not through any direct Iranian signature here.

DESIGN NOTE – WHY THIS CAN WORK: The Lebanese government supports state monopoly on arms. Israel and Lebanon already have a direct talks track scheduled in Washington (29 May). The U.S. has been the mediator since April 16. The missing piece is not diplomatic willingness — it is a 72-hour silence in which the Washington talks can actually happen. That is the only thing Track B asks of either party.

Article 6: Israeli Operational Pause

Upon entry into force of this Protocol, the State of Israel commits to an immediate pause on all offensive ground operations, air strikes, and artillery shelling inside Lebanese territory. The pause covers Tyre, Nabatieh, the Beqaa Valley, Beirut and its southern suburbs, Mashghara, and all other locations within Lebanon. Israeli forces currently inside Lebanese territory hold their positions and do not advance northward.

The pause does not cover legitimate defensive responses to direct kinetic attack on Israeli territory or forces. As in Track A, this exception is narrow: actual incoming fire or imminent physical threat to personnel — not surveillance, posture, or rhetoric.

Article 7: Lebanese State Commitments

The Lebanese Republic commits to two obligations during the freeze period:

- **Active suppression of cross-border fire.** The Lebanese Armed Forces will deploy to known Hezbollah launch points in southern Lebanon, in coordination with UNIFIL, and physically interpose between launch teams and the border. The LAF is not required to disarm Hezbollah units during the 72-hour period — only to physically prevent firing.
- **Confirmation of the 29 May Washington talks.** The Lebanese delegation will travel as scheduled. Any postponement requires 48 hours written notice to the U.S. facilitator and to Israel.

Article 8: The Hezbollah Question

Hezbollah is not a party to this Protocol and is not asked to sign anything. The Protocol does not, and cannot, require Hezbollah's consent. It does require the Lebanese state to use the means at its disposal — LAF deployment, coordination with UNIFIL, and political pressure — to physically prevent further cross-border fire during the 72-hour window.

Iran's contribution to Track B is delivered through Track A. As a confidence-building measure linked to the U.S. pause on strikes against Iran, Iran will privately convey to Hezbollah that an attack during the Track B freeze period will not be supported, supplied, or politically defended by Tehran. This commitment is documented in a diplomatic side-letter from Iran to the Omani facilitator and shared with the U.S. facilitator under seal. Neither the existence nor the content of the side-letter is made public during the freeze period.

Article 9: If Hezbollah Fires Anyway

A Hezbollah strike during the freeze does not automatically collapse Track B. Israel may respond defensively to incoming fire at the source of fire, calibrated to neutralise the immediate threat, without invalidating the broader pause. The Lebanese government is not held responsible for Hezbollah's actions, provided it has demonstrably attempted the LAF deployment required under Article 7. Track B collapses only if (a) a confirmed Hezbollah strike causes ten or more Israeli casualties within a single 24-hour period, or (b) the Lebanese government refuses or fails to deploy LAF under Article 7 within 12 hours of entry into force.

Part III: Linkage Between the Tracks

The two tracks are deliberately separable but linked at three points only. Anything outside these three linkages is independent.

Article 10: The Three Hard Linkages

- **Linkage 1 – Iran's leverage over Hezbollah.** Iran's commitment to withhold support from Hezbollah operations during the freeze (Article 8) is a Track A obligation as well as a Track B input. Documented failure of Iran to convey this message, if directly traceable, may be raised as a Track A compliance issue.
- **Linkage 2 – Synchronised entry into force.** Both tracks enter into force simultaneously upon oral confirmation by all four parties to their respective facilitators. If one track fails to achieve confirmation within 24 hours of the first confirmation received, the confirming parties may proceed unilaterally on a single-track basis at their discretion.
- **Linkage 3 – Independent collapse.** Collapse of one track does NOT collapse the other. If Track B fails — for example, by way of a confirmed large-scale Hezbollah strike causing significant Israeli casualties — the U.S.-Iran freeze in Track A continues uninterrupted. If Track A fails, the Israel-Lebanon freeze in Track B continues, with the United States as sole facilitator.

THE FIREWALL PRINCIPLE: Each track is firewalled from the other's failure. This is the most important structural feature of the dual-track design. A Hezbollah rocket, an IRGC mine, or an Israeli cabinet vote does not bring down the entire architecture. Each front fails or survives on its own. The Protocol is engineered for partial success even when partial failure is occurring elsewhere.

Part IV: What This Protocol Deliberately Excludes

To be agreed quickly, this Protocol must be narrow. The following issues are explicitly deferred to subsequent negotiation phases that this Protocol is designed to protect and enable:

Issue	Deferred To
Iran's HEU stockpile — custody, location, quantity	Track A MOU Phase 2
Enrichment moratorium — duration and scope	Track A MOU Phase 2
Sanctions relief — timing, tranches, reversibility	Track A MOU Phase 2
Frozen Iranian assets — release schedule	Track A MOU Phase 2
PGSA legal status and Hormuz governance	Track A MOU Phase 2

Issue	Deferred To
Hezbollah disarmament timeline and scope	29 May Washington talks & beyond
Israeli withdrawal from Lebanese territory	29 May Washington talks & beyond
Lebanese state monopoly on arms — enforcement	Internal Lebanese process
War reparations / reconstruction credits	Successor framework
Regional proxy activity in Yemen, Iraq, Syria	Separate regional track
Long-term nuclear enrichment rights	Successor framework

The exclusion of these issues is not weakness — it is architecture. Every prior negotiation collapsed because all sides attempted to resolve everything simultaneously. This Protocol resolves only the immediate operational question on each front: will the shooting stop long enough for the delegations now in motion to finish their work?

Part V: Verification – Minimal and Practical

Article 11: Joint Freeze Monitoring Cell (JFMC)

Oman, Qatar, and the United States each designate a single senior diplomatic officer as Compliance Monitor for the duration of the Protocol. These three officers form the Joint Freeze Monitoring Cell (JFMC). Oman holds Track A primacy; the United States holds Track B primacy; Qatar holds delegation-protection primacy. The JFMC has one function: to receive reports of alleged violations, assess them against the definitions in this Protocol, and communicate findings to all relevant parties within four hours.

The JFMC does not have authority to suspend the freeze, declare a breach, or impose consequences. Its role is purely informational. Consequences are governed by Article 12.

Article 12: Tiered Incident Response – No Hair Triggers

A single alleged violation does not suspend this Protocol. Both fronts are congested, high-tension operational environments. Accidents, miscommunications, and deliberate provocations by spoilers will occur. The Protocol survives them through a tiered response architecture applied identically to both tracks:

Tier	Trigger	Response	Timeline
1 — Incident	Single alleged violation reported to JFMC	JFMC notifies relevant parties; 4-hour consultation window opens; freeze continues	0–4 hours
2 — Pattern	Three Tier 1 incidents within 24 hours, or one confirmed lethal strike	JFMC convenes emergency session; foreign ministers contacted; 12-hour resolution window	4–16 hours
3 — Crisis	Large-scale offensive operation (10+ casualties or major infrastructure strike)	Facilitators convene in-person reconstitution within 6 hours; UN notified; freeze enters 'amber' status	6–24 hours
4 — Collapse	Written non-renewal notice filed by any Party	That track terminates after 6-hour buffer; the other track continues; humanitarian corridor survives	6 hours notice

The humanitarian corridor established in Article 4 survives all four tiers, including full Protocol collapse on either or both tracks. It is not subject to suspension, modification, or revocation by any Party under any circumstances during any active negotiation process.

Part VI: Entry Into Force and Duration

Article 13: Entry Into Force

This Protocol enters into force upon oral confirmation by authorised representatives of the participating Parties to their respective facilitators. Written signature is not required for initial entry into force. A joint written record of oral confirmation will be prepared by the JFMC within 12 hours and deposited with the UN Secretary-General.

The oral confirmation mechanism is deliberate. It allows all capitals to implement the freeze immediately without the domestic political exposure of signing a formal document under current conditions. The written record follows implementation — it does not precede it.

Article 14: Duration and Relationship to Subsequent Agreements

This Protocol has no fixed expiry date. Each track continues, auto-renewing every 72 hours, until superseded by a more comprehensive agreement specific to that track. Upon entry into force of a Track A MOU covering operational matters in Articles 1 through 5, Track A is automatically suspended in favour of the MOU. The same applies to Track B upon any agreement emerging from the 29 May Washington talks. If those subsequent agreements collapse, this Protocol automatically reactivates.

This Protocol is the floor, not the ceiling. It holds the space open. Everything built above it — the MOU on the nuclear file, the Washington framework on Lebanon, the sanctions architecture, the disarmament process — rests on the assumption that this floor does not fall away.

Annex A: Domestic Narrative Guide

This annex offers factually accurate talking points for each Party's domestic audience. All sets of statements describe the same Protocol truthfully.

Track A – Strait of Hormuz

For the United States	For the Islamic Republic of Iran
<i>“We achieved a complete operational pause on Iranian aggression in the Strait.”</i> <i>“Hormuz is open. Oil is flowing. No tolls.”</i> <i>“Iran's IRGC fast-attack boats are at anchor. Their mine-layers are stood down.”</i> <i>“We retain full carrier strike group positioning. We gave up nothing permanent.”</i> <i>“The nuclear file is next — we have 30 to 60 days to get maximum leverage.”</i>	<i>“The illegal blockade of Iranian commercial ports is suspended.”</i> <i>“Iran's PGSA sovereignty over the Strait is explicitly preserved — not conceded.”</i> <i>“Our delegation in Doha is protected and negotiating from a position of strength.”</i> <i>“The HEU stockpile remains on Iranian soil. Nothing was transferred.”</i> <i>“This freeze was Iran's choice — we can end it with six hours notice at any time.”</i>

Track B – Israel-Lebanon Border

For the State of Israel	For the Lebanese Republic
<i>“We achieved a 72-hour cessation of Hezbollah fire on northern Israel.”</i> <i>“The Lebanese state has been compelled to deploy LAF against Hezbollah launch sites.”</i> <i>“Israel retains all current positions inside Lebanon. We did not withdraw.”</i> <i>“We did not negotiate with Hezbollah, and we never will.”</i> <i>“The Washington talks of 29 May proceed from a position of strength.”</i>	<i>“The Lebanese state is exercising sovereign authority over its territory.”</i> <i>“Israeli airstrikes on Lebanese soil are paused. Civilian casualties stop.”</i> <i>“We are pursuing a peaceful resolution through direct talks, as we promised.”</i> <i>“The LAF, not any non-state actor, is the sole legitimate armed force in Lebanon.”</i> <i>“This Protocol respects Lebanese sovereignty and contains no foreign-imposed terms.”</i>

Annex B: Why This Protocol Is Achievable Today

Four factors make a minimal dual-track freeze achievable on 26 May 2026:

- 1. All delegations are already in motion.** The Iranian delegation is in Doha. U.S. counterparts are engaged. The Israeli and Lebanese delegations are due in Washington on 29 May. The facilitators are active on both tracks. The infrastructure for communication exists. This Protocol asks the parties to do one thing before anything else: confirm a freeze to the facilitators already sitting across from them.
- 2. Every leader can claim the freeze as a victory.** Trump has already said a deal is 'largely negotiated.' A freeze allows him to claim it has begun — on both fronts. Tehran has already said the blockade is illegal and the PGSA is sovereign; a freeze that suspends the blockade and preserves the PGSA's legal status allows Tehran to claim it has prevailed. Netanyahu can claim he forced Hezbollah fire to stop and the Lebanese state to deploy against Hezbollah. The Lebanese government can claim it has exercised state sovereignty and stopped Israeli airstrikes on Lebanese soil.
- 3. The cost of continued escalation is symmetric and high.** Today's strikes near Bandar Abbas rattled the Gulf and pushed oil prices higher. The strike on Mashghara killed twelve people including children. Iran's army has threatened a 'far more severe' response. Netanyahu is being urged by ultra-right ministers to resume strikes on Beirut. No party benefits from the next 72 hours of operational contact on either front.
- 4. The Protocol is explicitly not a surrender document.** Iran does not transfer the HEU. The U.S. does not lift sanctions permanently. The PGSA is not dissolved. Israel does not withdraw. Lebanon does not formally disarm Hezbollah. Hezbollah is not asked to sign anything. Nothing here cannot be walked back tomorrow. The only irreversible element is the humanitarian corridor — and every party can defend that to any domestic audience.

A NOTE ON TODAY'S STRIKES: The 26 May CENTCOM strikes near Bandar Abbas and the 26 May Israeli strikes near Mashghara and along the Litani are the triggering context — the reason urgency is real — not a fundamental breach of good faith. The question is not who struck last. The question is whether all four parties stop now.

Instruments of Acceptance

This Protocol may be accepted orally (confirmation to facilitators), in writing (signature below), or by electronic communication to the JFMC. All three methods produce identical legal effect. No domestic legislative approval is required for the initial 72-hour period.

Track A – Southern Front

For the United States of America

For the Islamic Republic of Iran

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date/Time: _____

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date/Time: _____

Track B – Northern Front

For the State of Israel

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date/Time: _____

For the Lebanese Republic

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date/Time: _____

Witness — Oman

Track A — primary

Witness — Qatar

Track A — delegation host

Witness — United States

Track B — primary